Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25860856.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Home

by Catrastrophic

Summary

Adora saved the cat and now it's time to bring her home.
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.
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"I don’t know how I’m supposed to act around you anymore. Because, yeah, we’ve always been friends and we slept in the same lodging for years - sometimes we even shared the same bed - but now I’m not sharing the bed with a friend; now I’m sharing it with my… my..."

Adora started to stammer, as if she couldn’t put the syllables together to form the word she wanted to say.

"I’m sorry, I didn’t get the last word, Adora. Your... what?” Catra smirked, casually inspecting her fingernails. Despite the relief of finally understanding all the reasons behind Adora's distress, seeing her stumble over the words was just priceless and Catra wanted to make the most of it.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"We're here!" Adora announced, motioning to a closed door and making Catra wince at her uncharacteristically high-pitched tone. "Uh, I mean: we're here."

She cleared her throat and repeated the sentence, trying to sound more like her normal self. But Catra had already noticed something was off and she narrowed her eyes, scrutinizing Adora, who gulped and forced a grin in response.

That didn't work as Adora had planned, though. She could see in Catra's face she hadn't found her grin cute, just creepy.

“Good. So are you going to tell me what the hell is going on now?”

Catra tried to hide her concern behind a façade of annoyance, but her body betrayed her. Apprehensiveness flashed in her eyes as her hands unwittingly made their way to Adora's in a touch that carried several meanings - none of them related to impatience or irritation. In fact, Catra had mimicked Adora’s comforting tactics unintentionally, maybe because that gesture had been deeply engraved in her unconscious ever since they were kids.

Her own reactions had come unnoticed, yet Catra perceived Adora's the second she touched her hand. While being cool and relaxed weren't exactly Adora's best features, she excelled at controlling her emotions whenever the moment required it. Signs of anxiety would surface only if Adora were under enormous stress, so not even a compliment from Shadow Weaver would have left Catra as stunned as she was now, holding those uncharastically cold, damp hands.

“Ugh, Adora, at least tell me if you are okay because, for the way you’re acting, I’m starting to think the last fight has finally got you brain damaged.”

“Oh, I’m fine! I’m great!” Adora let out a restrained chuckle, ignoring the teasing and quickly withdrawing her hands in hopes Catra wouldn’t have noticed their state. “Never been better!”

As she watched Adora's poorly executed attempt to pretend nothing was wrong - which consisted of her practically singing the last sentence and combining it with an exaggerated dismissive move - Catra crossed her arms and raised one of her eyebrows.

"Clearly.”

If Adora wanted to divert Catra’s attention from her sticky hands and that unusual behavior, she had obviously failed. Adora had always been a terrible liar - which was a good thing, actually - and Catra was *way* too smart to buy that lame excuse. She tried not to be offended by Adora underestimating her perspicacity; despite growing apart in the past three years, they knew each other very well.

Still, Catra couldn't understand *why* Adora was refusing to open up about whatever bothered her. She had already asked what was wrong - more than once, by the way - but that stubborn little princess would just say: *Oh, it’s nothing, I just wanna show you this place! We’ll get to talk when we get there!*

And now that they had supposedly arrived at this mysterious place, instead of opening that damn door, Adora was just stupidly staring at it with her hand on the knob.

"Uh, I just need a minute... Okay?" Apparently Adora had read her mind without even sparing a glance at her.

"Right… whatever you need."

Catra grumbled and furrowed her brow, analyzing Adora.

Why would she need a minute? Why would she have to steel herself just for opening a door?

Judging by Adora’s reaction, Catra wondered if there could be something frightening behind those walls, though that didn’t make any sense. They had just returned to Bright Moon after winning the war against Horde Prime. The castle had been inspected and deemed safe. And most importantly: everyone was okay,

sustaining only minor bruises and a few scratches at most. So Adora had no reason to be worried.

Yet, she was.

Actually, she had acted weird all the way back... *home?*

Catra hesitated on the last word, but apparently that's what Bright Moon would be from now on: her home. She just needed to get used to it, since that insanely colourful Kingdom was the complete opposite of the Fright Zone and Horde Prime's Flagship, the only places Catra had lived in so far. That alone would explain why her idea of *home* was so crooked and why it would take her some time to adjust.

It was not like she would miss those piles of junk, anyway. The Fright Zone became a living hell surrounded with painful memories after Adora left. And then the Flagship turned out to be Catra's worst nightmare… so much that she would wince and unconsciously touch her neck, right where the chip had been implanted, whenever that memory crossed her mind. Good thing Entrapta had managed to remove it before it could damage her for good.

Catra tried to push those thoughts aside. She didn't want to be haunted by the past anymore; her days of rage, anguish and frustration were gone, thanks to the beautiful - and also annoying - blond standing before her, who *still* had her hand on the knob.

Catra opened her mouth to utter a tease remark, changing her mind only when something dawned on her. Maybe Adora wasn't steeling herself; maybe she was just concentrating so she could perform one of those weird magics she had learned as She-Ra after she… left.

Her anger had already vanished, but reminding of how much she had missed Adora still hurt. Until that fateful day, Catra had never really imagined a life without her. They were supposed to call the shots in the Fright Zone someday; that was the plan. And for a

long time, Catra secretly dreamed of having her childhood friend back so things could be the way they were before.

Little did she know things would be even better than anything she had ever imagined.

Catra even felt her heart warm at the remembrance of Adora saying that she loved her too. Not even in her wildest dreams had Catra thought her love would be reciprocated, so gathering the courage to confess her feelings and then kiss Adora had really paid off in the end.

"Catra?"

Adora's voice pulled her out of her reverie. She had finally managed to open the door and, with a wavering smile, motioned for Catra to go in.

“Um. Right...” Catra nodded, warily.

She spared one last glance at Adora before taking the first step in. Those deep blue eyes fixed on her, staring in expectation and so Catra realized: no threat laid inside that room. Adora wasn’t scared nor concentrating; she was just... anxious.

How could I be so stupid? Of course this place is safe; otherwise, Adora would never ask me to go in! This idiot was likely to dive head first - and all alone, to make it worse - because she just can't wait to throw herself into danger if that means protecting her friends! Damn it!

Catra gritted her teeth and refrained from smacking herself. Adora was so very predictable, yet she had failed to see the signs. Maybe Adora’s mindlessness had become somehow contagious. The old Catra would never make such a mistake.

But then... why is she acting all weird? Is she plotting something? Is this some sort of surprise? -- No… she wouldn't dare.

Catra hated surprises and Adora knew that very well.

There was no point in guessing, anyway; once she entered the room, Catra would unravel the cause of Adora's distress.

So holding her breath and taking cautious steps, Catra finally got in. Her pupils contracted almost immediately, adjusting to the sunlight coming from the windows. She stood still, instinctively making as little noise as possible, while her vigilant eyes scanned the area.

Okay. An overly extravagant room, with arched roof and… definitely *a questionable decoration. Why do these people hang crystals everywhere? And why would they need a waterfall in here? Man, this place looks like the ones described in those softcore novels Scorpia kept in her locker--- uh, not that I've ever read any of them, of course. Anyway... moving on. There's also a double bed overrun with fluffy pillows and a desk with... a She-Ra doll on it?! No way! Is this…* **Adora's** *room?!*

Catra turned around and gawked at Adora, who stood by the door, chewing on her lower lip and repeatedly shifting her weight from foot to foot.

But… why would she make such a fuss about it? If Adora wanted to show her her room - supposing this stagy place was really her room - she didn’t need to be that nervous about it.

Sure, Catra would probably mock her for becoming a spoiled little princess with a waterfall in her cathedral-like bedroom, but that would be it. A little teasing was expected, especially coming from Catra, so why would Adora be so agitated in advance?

Unless…

Catra widened her eyes as something crossed her mind: what if Adora wanted to take back what she had said about loving her too? What if she had regretted bringing her to Bright Moon?

That made sense. Adora had said they would get to talk once they got there, because obviously such conversation would require a more private place. Adora wouldn't just break her heart right in

front of everyone. She wouldn't be that mean, not even to someone who really deserved it, like... Catra herself.

She felt a pang of despair and her eyes suddenly filled with tears.

No! Adora wouldn't do that. *Would she?*

Catra knew she had a lot to improve before she could measure up to Adora and her friends' level, but eventually she would get there. She just needed time... and also Adora by her side.

Catra didn't want to cry, but it was getting hard to fight back the tears. After all they had gone through, she just couldn't believe Adora would leave her like-

"Oh my god, you hated it even more than I thought you would!" Adora gasped when she noticed Catra's utterly disappointed expression. "I can see it in your face, Catra, you can tell me."

Catra blinked in confusion. Was this the way a breaking-up conversation was supposed to begin?

"Adora, I-"

"I know, I know, the decoration is a *little* too much. I thought exactly the same the first time I entered this room, but you get used to-- Wait!" Something clicked as Adora said the last words. She froze for a moment and then blinked a couple of times before sprinting to one of the windows and closing its curtain in one swift move. “There! Is it better now? I just recalled you're not used to bright places; the Fright Zone was terribly dark and the Flagship was in space, so duh, there wasn’t much light there either!"

“Adora, what are you talkin-”

Catra tried to ask, but Adora was too busy pacing around the room and talking to herself to notice it.

"Ugh! What is wrong with me?!" Adora grunted, smacking her own forehead. “It's not like I'm a bad planner. I'm actually a *great*

planner, you know. So how come I have missed this?! Of course a darker place would make you feel-”

"Adora! Listen to me!"

“...home.” Her voice trailed off as she heard Catra practically screaming her name.

She did make an attempt to resume her speech, but Catra quickly raised one finger in the air when she was just about to begin. So Adora froze at the silent command and remained ridiculously still, staring at her with lips parted.

Catra almost let out an audible sigh of relief at the realization Adora wasn’t breaking up their barely initiated relationship. Though that babbling was *really* confusing, Catra managed to grasp that Adora just wanted her to feel at… *home.*

"You are such an idiot..." Catra chuckled as she approached Adora, her expression now matching the tenderness in her voice. With a nimble movement, she opened the curtains Adora had just closed and then stared directly at her. "I don't mind the light, Adora. In case you haven’t noticed it, I'm a cat, not a vampire. "

The sunlight allowed Catra to see Adora's scowl, probably in response to her remark. She chuckled again and then caressed Adora's cheek with the palm of her hand, watching her expression gradually soften at the touch.

"Can I talk now?" Adora asked with a faint pout, which Catra found incredibly endearing.

"Yeah, but only if you promise you won’t start babbling again."

"I wasn't *babbling!"* Adora retorted indignantly, folding her arms. "I was just trying to explain that even though I’m an excellent planner - because I *really* am - I didn’t consider the fact you would-- Oh, never mind."

Adora huffed as she saw Catra smirking at her impending... babble.

"Is this your room, Adora?" Catra asked, trying to get Adora to focus. As she saw Adora nodding in response, she added. "I don't get it. You were *that* worried just because you thought I wouldn't like your room?!"

"Actually, I was afraid you wouldn't like... *our* room." Adora averted her stare as she added the last two words, blushing as she did so.

"Our room?" Catra raised her ears and also her brows.

"Yeah, I know it's hard to believe, but there aren't many rooms in this castle. So I asked Glimmer if she wouldn't mind if you, uh, stayed here… with me. And after she and Bow teased me mercilessly just for asking that - which was really unfair *and* incredibly annoying, by the way - Glimmer said: *Oh, of course I don't mind, Adora! You and Catra can be aaall alooone in your room, I bet you girls have sooo much to 'catch up', right?* And then she winked at Bow, so they both laughed and then resumed teasing me... Ugh! They just wouldn't stop! Can you imagine I had to put up with those two for over an hour and- Oh no." Adora gasped and brought her hands to her mouth, horrified. "Oh my god, you were right! I'm babbling! I'm a babble person! When did I start doing this?!"

Catra was staring at Adora with wide eyes and her mouth agape.

"Ugh, Catra! Could you please say something so I can stop babbling *and* embarrassing myself?!"

As she heard Adora practically whining, Catra blinked a couple of times and then burst into laughter.

"Good. Now you are laughing at me. Thank you *so much* for your support, Catra! It means a lot!" Adora grumbled, propping her hands on her hips.

As she noticed Catra bending over, laughing even harder at her ironic comment, Adora snorted audibly and stuck her nose up in the air.

“I can't believe it! Did Sparkles really say that?” Catra panted, finally managing to pull herself together. “By the way, your impersonation of Sparkles was awesome! Could you do it again? I loved the way your voice grew shrill, sounding exactly like hers! Man, I wish Double Trouble were here to see that!”

“Well, yeah, that's what Glimmer said." Adora grumbled, but with a considerably softer expression. "Those were her words exactly, including the extra vowels and all the innuendos.”

“So... she really won’t mind if I stay here in Bright Moon… with you?” Catra’s tone changed and she sounded almost timid when she asked the question. “I mean, I know I helped her escape from the Flagship, but I don’t want her to take me in only because she thinks she owes me a thing.”

“Catra, Glimmer doesn't like you because you saved her life!” Adora stated, reaching for Catra’s hands and squeezing them lightly. “Can’t you see? Glimmer and Bow are not *my* friends; now they are *your* friends too!"

"I- I don't know about that..."

"Oh come on! You know they think you’re funny. And cute.”

“Grr… I’m not cute!” Catra gritted her teeth and blushed, just like Adora had predicted she would.

In fact, Adora had added the last sentence precisely to get that reaction. In her opinion, Catra looked even cuter protesting against being cute.

“Well, just so you know, I think they are right.” Adora declared, watching the blush on Catra’s cheeks intensify. “Anyway… I just want you to know you are welcomed here, Catra. You have friends who care about you, who will always support you. And you've got,

well... me. I know I hurt you really bad and maybe it will take a long time until you can truly forgive me, but I promise you… I will never leave you again. Ever.”

“You won't?” Catra asked quietly, keeping her head low and fidgeting with Adora's fingers.

“Of course I won't!” As if to stress her words, Adora squeezed her hands again. “We belong together. Besides, *nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.* Remember?"

Catra looked up as she heard Adora quoting their childhood's motto.

"How could I forget?" Catra chuckled half-heartedly, averting her eyes.

While Adora's words had brought up fond memories, they had also triggered some hurtful ones related to her desertion and the events that followed it.

"Catra?" Adora called her hesitantly, drawing her attention. "What is it? Did I say something wrong?"

"No, you didn't. It's just that…." Catra trailed off, internally debating whether such a painful subject should be brought up now.

But maybe it was time they finally talked about everything that happened.

“What I mean is…”Catra‘s throat tightened and once again she stopped mid-sentence.

She had never been good at expressing her feelings, let alone with words, but she would try. She needed to get better. More than that, Catra wanted *to be* better. And she had already learned opening up to someone wasn’t a sign of weakness; it was rather the opposite.

"I get why you left, Adora." Her lips curled into a wistful smile that felt like a rope wrapping around Adora's heart, squeezing it harder and harder. "I think I always have, actually. But I was too stubborn and too hurt to admit it. You know, you were everything I had back then, at the Fright Zone. So when you left… you took my whole world with you. I felt so lost… so empty. And I ended up filling this void with a grudge and a rage that almost consumed me completely. I know, there's no excuse for that, but when I lost you… I thought… I thought I had nothing left to lose."

"Catra…" Adora breathed her name with eyes filled with tears. As much as she wanted Catra to start opening up about her feelings, Adora knew that was incredibly painful for her. And she didn't want Catra to hurt anymore. Or ever again. "We don't have to talk about this, if-"

"No, Adora. Please. Let me finish. I *need* to get this out of my chest."

Catra cut her off, while brushing Adora's tears with the back of her fingers. Her tone had been almost rude, but her touch had never been so tender.

"Over the past years, I started questioning my choices, but it was in the Flagship that everything really changed for me. Lord Prime... he wasn't a manipulable idiot like Hordak; he was smarter, more powerful, and he would never stop until he got what he wanted… and that included killing you. That wasn't one of our stupid fights, in which neither of us really meant to hurt the other; that was serious. So when he got Sparkles, I *knew* you would come for her; but you would fall right into his trap, he was waiting for you, he had already anticipated your every move. I had seen what he was capable of; I had witnessed the kinds of things he would do when he got his damn hands on you. And just the thought of him hurting you… it made me so sick, it hurt me so much, Adora... even more than it hurt when you left me."

Catra's voice quivered as she added the last words. She paused for a second, noticing Adora held her head low while decorating

the floor with her tears.

Her heart broke seeing Adora in that state, crying so hard yet so quietly. But as much as she wanted to comfort her right now, Catra had to finish what she had started. Otherwise, she feared she would never have the courage to bring up that subject again.

"Anyway… I couldn't just sit and watch, I had to do something to stop you from coming to that ship. So I found a way to send Sparkles to you; it was risky and I'd probably get killed for that, but you know what? When I managed to get her out of there, I felt happy and relieved - two things I hadn't felt in a long, long time. I finally had done something that made me proud of myself, something I thought it would make you proud too... So it didn't matter if Prime tortured me and then killed me for ruining his plans; he would *never* get his filthy hands on you and he would *never* take that pride away from me either!"

As Catra made a pause, her determined expression gradually changed into a melancholic one.

"As expected, his clones soon came after me. I didn't stand a chance, there were so many of them... Besides, even if I had taken them all down, I knew I wasn't strong enough to defeat Prime. No one was, except for... She-Ra. You were the only one who could defeat him, so I didn't mind dying if that meant you would be safe; your life was worth, Adora, while mine... wasn't. There was nothing left for me. I had driven away the few people that had ever cared about me and I was the one to blame; I had taken myself past a point of no return, because... well, even if I apologized for the things I had done, how could I expect *you* to forgive me when I had nearly destroyed the world you fought so hard to protect?! But at least I could do one good deed before I got killed, hoping it would not only keep you safe, but it would also make you hate me just a little less."

Catra paused again, inhaling and then slowly letting the air out from her parted lips. She tried not to think of the pain and despair that followed her capture. Her own voice, crying Adora's name

while Prime tortured and chipped her, still echoed in her ears. Hearing about that wouldn't do Adora any good, so Catra decided to spare her those details.

After she heard Catra's last sentence, Adora finally raised her head. Tears were still blurring her sight, but she *needed* to look at Catra in the eyes.

"I never hated you, Catra. I- I could never hate... you." Adora sniffed, brushing her tears with the back of her hand. There were so many things she wanted to say, but the words got stuck in her throat.

"I know." Catra smiled and wiped one stray tear that had barely left Adora's eye. "You have always been a good person. In fact, it was you who inspired me to do the right thing in the end."

"Me?"

"Yes, silly! Who else?!" Catra chuckled at Adora's dumbfound expression. "It's *you* who always saves the day, remember? You *always* do the right thing, Adora. This is incredibly annoying, by the way, but apparently I love you the way you are, annoying and all."

Catra shrugged with mock indifference, then smiled as she saw Adora laughing despite the tears that were insisting on running down her cheeks.

"And because of that," Catra went on, "because you always do the *right* thing, I never thought you would come back… *for me.* You had no reason to; in fact, you had every reason to leave me there to die. But instead... you came. You came when I needed you the most. In that very moment, when I saw you in that damn ship, I finally realized: you had *never* left me; you had *never* broken your promise. You didn't give up on me, not even when I deserved it and not even when I myself did. So I… I just wanted to say… thank you. Thank you for saving me and... I'm sorry too… for all the hurt I've caused you; for every stupid decision I've made. I

wish I could go back and do everything differently, but… since I can’t, at least I can promise you I’ll never stop trying to be a better person.”

When Catra finished, Adora just threw herself in her arms, clinging to her almost desperately. Her hands tangled in Catra’s short hair and, as she buried her nose in her neck, Adora started sobbing again.

“Hey Adora…” Catra whispered her name sofly, while stroking her back. “You don’t need to cry. It’s okay. I’m okay.”

Adora straightened herself and brought her hands to cradle Catra’s cheeks, finally realizing Catra had been crying too. She focused on those watery eyes for a moment, then dropped the stare to Catra’s lips. At the feeling of anticipation, Adora trembled almost imperceptibly and she slowly leaned forward, her eyes closing just a second before their lips met.

It was an impassioned kiss, to which Catra responded after a moment, since she wasn’t expecting Adora to kiss her right after an outburst.

So, two seconds later, Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's waist, keeping her close, the closest their bodies had ever been. There was so much loving in Adora’s kiss… as if she was trying to convey all her feelings through that one gesture.

The kiss, though incredibly deep, didn't last long. After a moment, Adora pulled back slightly, standing close enough to touch Catra's forehead with her own. She let out a content sigh and brought her palms to Catra's cheeks again, closing her eyes as she caressed them.

Catra could see Adora was still a little giddy and her breathing seemed slightly increased, just like hers. The fact this last kiss had been so intense to the point of stirring up such strong emotions in both of them came as a surprise. Catra didn’t know how to describe what she had just felt, nor why it had resonated through

her whole body, inside from outside, giving her goosebumps all along.

Whatever that was, she wanted to feel that again. More than that, Catra wanted Adora to feel exactly the same.

"Thank you… for trusting me.” Adora broke the silence. "I can imagine how hard it is for you to talk about these things.”

"Don't thank me. I was selfish - you even tried to stop me and I didn’t let you. All I could think was that I *had* to do this, but after seeing you crying so hard, I wished I had kept everything to myself…”

Catra turned her head to the side, her throat tightening as the image of Adora sobbing blinked in her mind.

As she noticed Catra averting the stare, Adora cupped her chin in her hand, gently guiding her face so their eyes could meet again.

"The fact I’ve caused you so much pain, even though I never meant to, still hurts me... But I’m glad you found a way to understand my reasons for leaving the Horde. Plus, everything worked out in the end, right? I mean... you are here with me now...” Adora combined her words with a reassuring smile. "Those weren’t just tears of sadness, Catra. They were mostly tears of happiness and relief."

“Good. But I don’t want to see you crying like that ever again. This silly smile fits you way better than all those tears.” Catra stated, motioning to Adora’s lips.

"That’s because I’m happy”. Adora’s smile bloomed into a broad grin. “The happiest I've ever been in my whole life.”

"It’s only natural. After all, you saved the world. You should be proud of it.”

Though that remark resembled the countless provocations Catra had hurled at Adora in the past, this time her voice was deprived

from sarcasm. Actually, there was a hint of sincere respect and admiration that didn't go unnoticed by Adora.

“I’m not happy because I saved the world, Catra.” Adora's expression turned serious as she added. “I’m happy because *you* saved *me.”*

Catra parted her lips, but before she could say anything, Adora held her hands and went on.

“You know, saving the world is a good reason to die for. But you, Catra… when you told me that you loved me, you gave me a reason to *live.”*

Catra blinked, completely taken aback. She wanted to say something in return, even though she highly doubted there would be a response to that statement.

Since no words came out from her lips, her body provided the answer, for her heart trembled in her chest and her eyes filled with tears.

As she noticed Catra's reaction, Adora quickly stepped in, in hopes of loosening her up a little.

"I mean, *Catra* had said she loved me, so I couldn’t just die without making sure I had heard it right!” She added humorously, watching Catra’s unshed tears fall all at once as she chuckled.

At that moment, Adora wondered if her heart would ever stop fluttering whenever she saw Catra smiling truthfully like this.

For a minute, both just stood there, staring at each other with silly matching grins, until something crossed Adora’s mind.

“You never answered me.”

Catra frowned at the unexpected comment.

"Answered... what?"

“You never told me if you hated this room.” She clarified, bringing the subject up again.

“No, I didn’t hate it. It’s a bit too fancy for my taste, but after sleeping for years in that shabby lodging in the Horde, you know I can sleep pretty much anywhere.” Catra laughed before adding almost timidly. “So if Sparkles is really okay with it, and as long I get to stay with you, any place is fine."

“Of course she’s okay with it! Actually, Glimmer was *really* excited about you moving in. She even asked me to let her take care of all the details and, uh... that would explain the new decoration and also… the double bed that *definitely* wasn’t here before!”

Only then Adora noticed the recently improved piece of furniture, topped with lots of pillows and even… *rose petals?!*

Adora almost shrieked, thinking either that was a bad joke or Glimer had definitely lost her mind. She felt her face burn and wondered if her cheeks were matching the color of her jacket. If so, would Catra have noticed it?

Or worse… would Catra have noticed the rose petals?!

Adora thought she was starting to have a panic attack - or maybe a stroke. She needed to calm herself down, so she inhaled and exhaled a couple of times, telling herself she was overreacting.

So it’s a double bed. Pfff. Big deal! We have slept in the same ***single bed*** *thousands of times before and-- wait. I've said it right: that was* ***before.*** *Things have changed, Catra isn’t just a friend anymore! Well, Catra has never really been* ***just a friend,*** *but now… now we are more than friends. Now we are... girlfriends? That’s what people call two girls who date each other, right? (...) Would Catra let me call her ‘my girlfriend’?*

“Adora?”

“What?!” Adora practically jumped out of her skin when Catra's voice interrupted her babbling thoughts.

“You spaced out.” Catra frowned, narrowing her eyes at her. "Please don’t tell me you are still worried about me not liking this room."

"No, that's not what's bothering me. It’s just... only now I noticed Glimmer had added a *double* bed to this room and… you know..." Adora let the subtle meaning of that furniture linger in the air, mainly because she didn’t know how to clearly express what was in her head.

"So…?” Catra shrugged, unaffected. She had spotted the double bed the minute she walked in, but she just assumed it had always been there. The fact Glimmer had replaced Adora’s single bed with a double one, just because she was moving in, did surprise her a little. “I don’t know why you are freaking out about this. It’s not like we have never slept in the same bed before..."

"Yes! That's exactly what I said!"

“You did? To whom?" Catra wanted to stop frowning, but Adora wasn’t making it easier for her.

"Um... to myself?" Adora chuckled nervously, before giving up and just sighing. "I’m sorry. You are right, I freaked out! But that’s only because things have changed between us after you... kissed me…"

"Yeah… but you didn’t look that troubled until we were on our way back to Bright Moon.” Catra noted, somewhat despondent. “You’re making it sound like this *change* was a bad thing...”

“NO! No, Catra. It’s a good thing. It’s a *great* thing, actually. I swear!” Adora hurriedly added. “It’s just… weird. I don’t know how I’m supposed to act around you anymore. Because, yeah, we’ve always been friends and we slept in the same lodging for years - sometimes we even shared the same bed - but now I’m not sharing the bed with a *friend;* now I’m sharing it with my… my..."

Adora stammered, as if she couldn't put the syllables together to form the word she wanted to say.

"I'm sorry, I didn't get the last word, Adora. *Your...* what?" Catra smirked, casually inspecting her fingernails. Despite the relief of finally understanding all the reasons behind Adora's distress, seeing her stumble over the words was just priceless and Catra wanted to make the most of it.

"Ugh, Catra! You know what I mean!" Adora grunted and blushed a little when she finally gathered the courage to say. "Now I'm sharing the bed with… with my... girlfriend."

"Girlfriend?!" Catra frowned theatrically, as if Adora had spoken the word in the First One's language. "There must be a mistake, Adora. I don't recall you asking me to be your girlfriend."

Adora gritted her teeth and, just when she opened her mouth to complain about how annoying Catra could be, something crossed her mind.

"Wait a minute!" Adora gave a half-suppressed laugh and then looked at Catra in amused surprise. "Don't tell me you want me to, like, get on one knee and ask you to be my girlfriend."

"Well… I *did* bring you back from the dead, right? You said it yourself. So it's about time you take some initiative in this relationship." Catra faked a yawn while observing Adora through the corner of her eye.

As she heard Adora snorting, Catra even had to press her lips together so a laugh wouldn't escape.

Honestly, Catra had never considered making her do such a cheesy thing, but since Adora herself had come up with the idea… she wouldn't just dismiss it.

Meanwhile, Adora was scrutinizing Catra's expression and, seeing that little smirk popping up on her lips again, she vowed she would wipe it off her face when Catra least expected it.

Two could play that game.

“Well, Catra, this comes as a surprise to me. I mean, I never thought you were a romantic, but… if that’s what you want, alright then.” Adora assented, getting on one knee and holding Catra’s hand. “So… do you, Catra, take me as your girlfriend?”

First Catra widened her eyes, surprised at the fact Adora had *really* got on one knee, but then she smirked again.

“Oh, Adora. This is so unexpected... I need some time so I can think abou- hey!”

Catra yelped as Adora suddenly pulled her down.

“No, you stubborn brat!” Adora declared in a fake evil voice as she straddled Catra, pinning both her wrists to the ground with one hand while mercilessly tickling her with the other. “You are gonna answer me now!”

“NO, ADORA, STOP!” Catra cried out, laughing nervously as the tickle assault went on. She tried to avert Adora’s hand, but the girl had caught her off guard completely. “You know I hate tickles, so stop!!”

“That’s what you get for teasing me and also for being so annoying!” Adora tried to remain serious, but she just couldn’t stop laughing. Even so, her grip on Catra’s wrists didn't waver the slightest. “I won’t stop until you answer my question!”

“Okay! Alright! You won! Now stop!” Catra gave up, laughing and panting at the same time.

Her back was still on the floor as she stared up. The sight of Adora straddling her, the golden hair up on a ponytail with a few loosen locks, her cheeks painted in a light shade of pink while she panted, staring down… Catra felt her heart skip a beat at just how gorgeous Adora looked.

“So…?”

Her voice forced Catra to focus on what was happening in the real world.

"You want your answer, right? Fine. First you let go of my wrists, then you'll get your answer."

"No. Way." Adora punctuated each word while getting even closer, practically rubbing her smirk on Catra's face. "I'm not as idiot as you think. I'm not letting you escape."

"Oh. Finally getting smarter, princess?! I'm really impressed." Catra sniggered, then she added in a hoarse voice. "But who said I wanted to escape from you?"

Adora widened her eyes as she heard the rhetorical question. Those words, combined with the way Catra was staring at her, so defiantly yet so comfortable, as if she didn't mind being... dominated...

Wow.

Suddenly Adora became acutely aware of just how close they were, which aroused new sensations in her. Heat quickly coursed through her whole body up to the tips of her ears and her pupils dilated, making her blue eyes look darker. Adora could feel her mouth getting drier and drier as she wondered what it would feel like if their skins were touching without any fabric between them.

"You're still waiting for your answer, aren't you?" Catra's sultry voice broke her trance. "Of course I *take you as my girlfriend,* you idiot. That was a stupid question, even for you."

"Good girl." Adora praised her in a mocking tone. Still straddling Catra, and emboldened by the yearning she had just seen reflected in those almond-eyes, Adora got even closer and added in a mischievous tone. "Should I also beg for you to stay in this room and sleep with me?"

"Oh my God!!"

A muffled cry of horror caught their attention just when Catra was about to answer, so they immediately turned their heads only to see Glimmer, pressing a hand over Bow's mouth.

"Bow!" Glimmer gritted her teeth as she realized they had just been caught. "This is all your fault! If you hadn't screamed, I would have teleported us before they even noticed we'd been here!"

"Wait a minute! This is *my* fault?! Glimmer! This would *never* have happened if you had just listened to me! This was a bad, bad idea!" Bow snorted, folding his arms in front of his chest. "I told you! They are a couple now and couples do… *things,* when they are alone!"

Catra and Adora blinked a couple of times, still paralized.

"I get that! But still!" Glimmer argued, stomping her feet on the ground as she elongated the last word. "I thought they would at least *talk* for a while, instead of just jumping into action-"

"Hey!"

Catra cried out, cutting Glimmer out and finally getting their attention. She untangled herself from Adora, which made the girl snap out of her shock, and then got back to her feet.

"We didn't just *jump into action!* In fact, we were *talking* when you interrupted us!" Catra hissed, trying to keep a scowl on her face to hide her embarrassment. "By the way: why are you here? And most importantly: why couldn't you just knock, like normal people do?!"

"See?!" Bow pointed at Catra, but with eyes still on Glimmer. "She said *exactly* what I said to you! You have to start using doors, Glimmer! Doors exist for a reason! You can't just *teleport* into a couple's room!"

"Okay! Fine! No more teleporting into couples' rooms! Are you happy now?!" She grumbled and then sharply turned at her new

target. “Now *you,* Adora!”

“Me?! What about me?!” Adora jumped to her feet and straightened herself as she heard Glimmer yelling her name.

The Queen of Bright Moon furrowed her brows, but her expression turned softer and her tone more sympathetic when she positioned herself right in front of her friend, putting both hands on her shoulders.

“It’s okay, Adora. I get that you want Catra *so much* you can’t even wait to get your hands all over her. That’s good. That’s healthy, even. In fact, if I dated Catra, I would do exactly the same thing!” Glimmer didn’t seem to notice the mortified look on Adora’s face nor Bow’s mouth hanging open, and so she went on, changing her tone dramatically now. “But for God’s sake! Have a little self-respect! You shouldn’t have to *beg* for someone to sleep with you, let alone harass them to get what you want!”

“Hey- WHAT?!” Adora shrieked and then grunted when she heard Catra guffawing next to her. “Just so you know, I wasn’t *begging* for Catra to sleep with me!”

“Yes, you were! We saw it and we heard you clearly! Tell her, Bow!” Glimmer insisted, passing the torch to Bow.

“Uh, Adora... this time, Glimmer is actually right. We got in here just in time to hear you begging… and harassing Catra.” Bow added cautiously, earning a smile from Glimmer, for standing up for her, and a scowl from Adora. Then, he turned his head to Catra and his eyes watered as he recalled that horrendous moment. “Poor thing, she looked so scared! So defenseless, pinned to the ground.”

“No, she didn’t, because *first:* Catra is anything but defenseless; and *second,* I wasn’t harassing anyone, much less *begging* for her to sleep with me! I don’t need to beg for *that!”* Adora retorted indignantly, suddenly shoving Catra forward. “Go on, Catra. Tell

them you want to sleep with me as much as I want to sleep with you."

"Uh…" Catra bit her lower lip, frowning at Adora. "You *do* realize you are making things worse, right?"

"Nooo…" Adora drawled, pretending she hadn't agreed with Catra. "Anyway, you two haven't answered the question! What are you doing here?!"

"Well, we just wanted to bring Catra some welcome gifts!" Glimmer chirped, visibly excited. "Bow?"

"Yeah, right!" Bow took a step forward and picked up a huge box that had been on the ground. "We were supposed to come earlier, but we decided to use my dads' library to do a little research first. I mean, it's the first time we have a cat, so we didn't know what kind of gifts Catra would like."

"The first time you ***have*** *a* ***cat?"*** Catra sibilated and Adora wisely put her hands on Catra's shoulders from behind, preventing her from jumping into her friends' throats.

"Here! I hope you like it!" Bow declared proudly, unaware of Catra's deadly stare aimed directly at him.

Reflexively, she held the box in her hands, immediately noticing its size did not match its weight.

"It's... empty." She glared at Bow as she opened it, just to confirm her suspicions. "You gave me an empty box?! What the hell-"

"Precisely! It's a *huge* empty box, perfect for you to get in! We found out cats love empty boxes! Oh my god, you are gonna be the cutest little thing in it! And you can also use it to hide from Adora whenever you need it!"

"I- what?!" Catra gawked, as if not believing her ears.

"Hey, why would she even need to hide from me-"

“Okay! My turn!” Glimmer was practically bouncing around the room, just waiting for a chance to cut in. Whether she noticed the murderous look on Catra’s eyes or Adora’s confused expression, it didn’t matter; nothing would have stopped her anyway.

So Glimmer picked up another box from the ground and, grinning broadly, extended her arms so Catra could take it.

Catra glanced at Adora first, who offered her a strained smile. By no means she wanted to be rude, especially not after Glimmer had been so kind to add a double bed to Adora’s room and also bring welcoming gifts. So, seeing no way out, Catra accepted the box and involuntarily compared its weight to the one Bow had given her. Since it was way heavier, probably there would be something inside, but whether that was a good or a bad thing, Catra didn’t know. She sensed it would be the latter, so she tried to prepare herself for the worst.

As soon as she saw what was inside, Catra’s first thought was she should have left Glimmer to die on the Flagship, because now she would have to kill her with her bare hands, right in front of Adora.

“A mouse toy?!” She asked rhetorically, feeling one of her eyelids twitch as she picked up the mouse by its tail and held it in the air. “A scratching post?! And... what the hell is *catnip?!”*

Catra squinted her eyes, reading the tiny words written on a little bottle.

“Yes! Isn’t it cute?” Glimmer chuckled excitedly, motioning to the little mouse! “You can play with *Mr. Mousey* whenever you want to put your hunting instincts into practicing! And the scratching post is for you to sharpen your nails on an appropriate device, instead of using Adora’s skin! You don’t wanna risk leaving her all scarred, do you? As for the catnip, actually, this is for Adora.”

Glimmer plucked the bottle from Catra’s hand and handed it to Adora.

“I heard this thing can make a cat go *really* wild.” She winked at Adora suggestively and then added in a low voice. “Please don’t spare me the details later.”

“I’m. Not. A CAT!” Catra fumed and glared at them with claws extended, finding their faces *way* more appealing than that damn scratching post.

“Actually, you said earlier that you *were* a cat, not a vamp-“

“I mean, I’m not a *regular* cat!” Catra cut off Adora, narrowing her eyes at her and then back at Bow and Glimmer. “So could you stop treating me like I was a stupid pet?!”

She blurted out in a fit of rage, sounding exactly like the old Catra would.

That bothered her enormously, apparently even more than it had bothered the others. Catra knew she had been rude, so she quickly changed her tone to a softer one before anyone had the chance to chide her.

“I’m sorry. What I mean is… I appreciate your efforts.” She said the last sentence through gritted teeth and then started counting to ten while trying to swallow her rage.

Surprisingly, she managed to do that easier and faster than she had anticipated. After a brief moment, her ears flattened and Catra stared down as she spoke, sounding completely sincere this time.

“Actually, I wanted to thank you two, for accepting me here and also for trying so hard to make me feel at home, even though you *clearly* have no idea of what to do."

Adora was almost swooning at the sight of Catra trying so hard to be nice, while Bow and Glimmer just smiled proudly at the success of their mission.

“You’re welcome, Horde scum!” Glimmer teased, but Catra knew the old epithet didn’t carry any offensive meaning, not anymore.

“Best friends’ squad is finally home!” Bow cried out, pulling everyone to a hug,

As much as Catra hated to admit, she did like those dorks. She couldn’t hold back a smile at the feeling of being accepted and appreciated, even though in a awry way. But they were trying… and, against all odds, they were succeeding in making her feel like she belonged.

So… Is this what home feels like? Catra wondered with a faint smile.

“Okay…” Bow said after a moment, directing his stare at Glimmer. “We should get going and leave these two alone so they can, uh, *resume* whatever they were doing.”

“Yeah, right!” Glimmer quickly agreed, then she turned to Adora and Catra. “I hope you like the rose petals Perfuma added especially for your first night together!”

“Wait! You asked Perfuma to come here and fill the bed with rose petals?” Adora could almost feel a vein throbbing on her forehead.

“Actually, when I told the other princesses Catra would stay in your room, Perfuma offered to prepare your bed in the custom of her people; apparently, besides helping the newlyweds relax, the rose petals also have an aphrodisiac effect! Sooo... have fun, you two!”

She sang and grinned almost mischievously, but as soon as she touched Bow’s shoulder to teleport them to her own room, something very important came to her mind.

“Uh, guys… speaking of *having fun...*” Glimmer looked at Catra and Adora while trying to come up with appropriate words to ask the question. “Should we, uh, let the guards know you two are going to… you know… get laid?”

“WHAT?!” Adora gasped. “Why would you tell them that?! Who said we were going to… uh… *do* what you just said we would?! And even if we were going to do *that,* I don’t think the guards would have to be notified about it! This is private, you know! Besides, it’s not because we have *rose petals* on our bed that we have to… I mean, unless Catra wants it too, because if she does, I’m totally into--”

As Adora continued to babble nervously, Catra just stared at Glimmer, shaking her head as if she couldn’t believe what she had just heard. That girl *clearly* had no idea what the word *limit* meant.

“Well…” Bow stepped in, trying to help Glimmer, because she had just made it pretty obvious subtlety wasn’t her thing. “I’ve mentioned we did a little research in my dads’ library, right? So we *might* have found out that cats are rather loud when they… uh…”

“What Bow is trying to say is that cats tend to scream really *loud* when they are… - uh, what was the word again, Bow? - ...copulating?”

“WHAT?!” Catra shrieked in a high-pitch tone she had never reached before. Noticing her reaction had even made them wince and, therefore, had compromised any argument she could possibly present from that moment on, she forced a hoarse, casual voice. “I mean, I’m not *loud* and I *certainly* do not scream on such occasions.”

Soon after the words left her mouth, Bow and Glimmer noticed Adora standing a little behind Catra with eyes blazing in the same light-blue color of She-Ra’s. She even looked taller and stronger than her usual self.

“Care to explain how you know *that,* Catra?!”

The cold way Adora had uttered that sentence, especially the last word, made Catra flinch and then turn around.

“W-what?!” Catra gawked at her. “Hey, Adora, I-"

“No! Don’t you *'hey, Adora'*-me now! Go on. Tell me! It was Scorpia, wasn’t it?” Adora went on in an accusing tone. “I knew *wildcat* meant something! Ugh, it makes total sense! You were her date for Frosta’s Ball! God, I can’t believe you had a fling with Scorpia! Or was it more than just a fling?! Were you… *in love* with her?!”

As Adora kept bombarding her with questions, Catra could only stare back in complete shock.

“Um, I think *now* would be the perfect time for you to use the box I gave you." Bow elbowed Catra and whispered his advice in her ear.

“Are you kidding?!” Glimmer appeared right next to Catra’s other ear, almost crying out and definitely ruining Bow’s plans of being stealthy. “Look at her, Bow! Adora is strong, *plus* she has a sword! This will require more than just a box for her to hide in! Catra, do you want me to teleport you away from here? I'll be glad to save your life, just like you saved mine!"

“You two. Leave. Now.” Adora commanded roughly, glaring first at Glimmer and Bow and then at her soon-to-be dead girlfriend. “Catra and I need to talk.”

“Right away!” Bow grinned nervously at Adora and then he turned to Catra one last time, whispering. "It was really nice meeting you. I’ll miss your cuteness.”

"Don’t be such a pessimist, Bow! Remember! We read in those books that cats have nine lives! Let’s hope Catra hasn't run out of hers yet!” Glimmer added with a hopeful expression, touching Bow’s shoulder. And before she teleported them to a safer place - meaning any place without an enraged Adora in it - she stared directly at Catra. "Good luck! I really hope you can make it!"

Soon after they disappeared, Catra blinked a couple of times and then burst into laughter.

“Oh, my god, Adora! You are such a genius! I gotta admit, pretending that you were jealous and that *we needed to talk* was a brilliant idea to get those two out of here!" Catra was still laughing, but as she noticed Adora just silently glaring at her with hands crossed over her chest, her laughter faded. “Wait. You can't possibly be serious.”

Adora didn't say anything; instead, she just huffed and turned around not to face her.

"Adora! Are you...” Catra let the question linger, for she just couldn't believe Adora was actually jealous.

"What if I am?” She grumbled.

"Then you are even dumber than I thought.” Catra cooed in her ear, wrapping her arms around Adora’s waist from behind, feeling her stiff slightly in response. "Come on, Adora. Turn around. Talk to me."

Adora remained still and, after a brief moment, she let the air out of her lungs in one blow.

"I know I have no right to say anything, Catra. I'm the one who left, I’m not in the position to complain about you finding someone else to… *distract* you.” Adora tried to reason despite her disappointment. “I just-- I thought that kiss had been your first kiss too… I thought this was as new to you as it is to me, and that we would get to learn everything, together. So I guess I’m just upset my assumptions were wrong-"

"But they are right. At least, the last ones are.” Catra clarified and briskly, yet carefully, turned Adora in her arms so they could face each other. “Do you really think I could just *replace* you? Yeah, you left me, but my heart never let you go. You know that."

“Catra…” Adora was visibly taken aback. "So you and Scorpia… you two, you didn’t-"

“Of course not! Scorpia is my friend! I, on the other hand…" Catra grumbled the last sentence, still ashamed of her previous behavior. She wondered if she would ever learn how to live with all that guilt and regret. "I should have treated her better; Scorpia is a good person and she has always been a good friend, even though I didn’t deserve it. But that’s just it. As for that stupid ball, I couldn’t be *her date,* not even if I wanted to! You spent the whole night chasing after me, remember? In fact, anyone who looked at me would think I was with *you* and not with Scorpia!”

Adora chuckled as she recalled that Ball. Though Catra had been a real pain in the ass throughout the night, Adora had enjoyed their first dance together. The closeness of their bodies, the way Catra had held her in her arms and stared at her... Adora had even lost count of how many times she had reminisced about that moment.

She wondered if Catra had already figured out her own feelings back then.

When did their friendship turn to love, anyway?

"Before you kissed me, in the Heart of Etheria… you said you had always been in love with me.” Adora brought that subject up in such an unexpected way it made Catra frown a little and cock her head to the side. “When did you know? I mean, what made you realize you actually… *loved* me?”

“I… don’t know.” Catra answered sincerely. “I guess I’ve always known it subconsciously, but maybe it began to sink in when you left, because it hurt and I… well, I missed you. I *really* missed you. Everything became meaningless after you were gone. And I don't think I would have felt this way if you were just a friend.”

Catra noticed Adora frowning, apparently searching for any signs she might have missed, and she decided to return the question.

“What about you? I guess you didn’t realize you loved me only when you heard me saying I loved you..."

“No. I already knew.” Adora answered without a second thought. “But my whole life, it was never about what I wanted - it was rather about what I was supposed to do. So, when I left the Horde - when I left *you* - I wasn’t thinking about what *I, Adora,* wanted. I had just found out I was She-Ra and so I had this mission, I had to protect Etheria… and I..."

Catra caressed Adora’s cheek with the back of her fingers, noticing the girl sigh and then close her eyes. Apparently Adora needed to get some things out of her chest too and Catra would listen, even though she knew that could evoke some painful memories.

“That's okay.” Catra said softly. “I got angry at you because, when you left, you told me you would be back soon… And then I found out you had no intention of coming back at all, so I thought: *was she just going to leave me here, waiting for her, not caring enough to come and tell me she had found better friends and that she would rather be with them now?* Yeah, I know I was stupid. It took me some time - actually, a lot of time - but now I understand why you left and why you couldn't just come back."

"Actually, I didn’t even have time to consider coming back and talking to you. I was Bow and Glimmer’s prisoner - or something like that - and I had just found out the Horde had been manipulating us. I was utterly confused, thinking that my whole life had been a lie.” Adora frowned deeply, but then her expression softened. “No, not my whole life. *You* weren’t a lie. Leaving the Horde was easy; leaving *you* was what hurt me the most. I couldn’t just put my duties aside, I had never done that, but... one day I finally dared to ask myself what I wanted. And before I could even give it a thought, the image of you just popped in my head. So I had my answer; what I wanted ... what I’ve always wanted, Catra… it was *you.”*

Adora’s words seemed to have drained the air from the atmosphere because Catra found herself unable to breathe after hearing them.

"Still...” Adora went on, smiling faintly. "It didn’t matter what I wanted; saving Etheria was all that mattered - or so I thought. But there, in the Heart, I had a vision of Mara -- the She-Ra before me -- and she asked me the same question I had asked myself before: *'What do you want when this is all over?'* Then, she told me I was worth more than what I could give to other people and that I deserved love too. Hearing another She-Ra saying those words hit me really hard and I finally allowed myself to think that maybe… just maybe… if you loved me too, then we… we could…”

Adora trailed off as she saw Catra inhale deeply and lean forward with eyes shut. By the time their lips touched, she had already forgotten what she was going to say.

So Adora closed her eyes too and even in her daze, she noticed depriving herself from the sense of sight had made her acutely aware of all the other senses. Catra’s taste and the warmth of her skin, the scent emanating from her body, those soft moans escaping her lips as Adora deepened the kiss…

Suddenly she found herself craving for more. Out of sheer instinct, she grabbed Catra by the waist, bringing her closer without breaking the kiss. Adora had always been impressed at how Catra could easily pass through incredibly small gaps during their trainings, like no other cadet could. Now, as Adora felt her melting into her arms, she was convinced Catra really had the power to liquefy.

Soon, a pair of arms wrapped around her neck and Adora became mildly aware of Catra’s nails running through her scalp before undoing her ponytail. That light scratch triggered a wave of electricity that ran from Adora’s head down to her spine, echoing through her whole body.

For someone who had never allowed herself to *want* something, experiencing such strong *desire* was just… mind-blowing. And also somewhat scary, because now her body seemed to be acting of its own accord and she had no idea of how to make it stop.

For a brief second, Adora considered stepping back while she still had the strength to do so. Maybe she should take the time to think things through… or run to Bow's dads' library to try and learn more about *what the hell* she was supposed to do next.

Would there even be a book to teach that?!

The soft moans that had been escaping their throats quickly escalated and Adora wished she had taken Glimmer's offer to warn the guards into account as she realized that, instead of breaking the kiss, she had guided them to…

She gulped as she saw herself over Catra, both panting after their lips involuntarily pulled apart when they collapsed onto the bed.

Catra opened her mouth, as if she was going to say something, but no words came out. She just raised a quivery hand to Adora's lips and, gazing at them through half-lidded eyes, brushed the lower lip delicately with her thumb.

"Catra…" Adora shut her eyes for a moment, breathing her name as she felt another wave running through her body in response to that touch.

She leaned forward to kiss Catra again, but then she saw those slit eyes brimming with tears.

"Catra? What's wrong? Did I hurt you?" Adora asked worriedly, pressing her palms against the mattress so she could raise her torso and inspect Catra properly.

Catra didn't say anything in response; she just rolled from the bed and got up, turning away from Adora.

That was… completely unexpected.

"Catra, I'm sorry…" Adora leaned on her forearm as she tried to understand what she had done wrong. She thought Catra wanted that to happen too, but apparently she had mistaken the signs. "I don't know why I got carried away like this; I should have taken

things slowly. I never meant to make you feel uncomfortable, I swear."

“You didn’t.” Catra finally turned around, staring at Adora with a sad smile. The tears filling her eyes started running down her cheeks, despite her efforts to fight them back. “You didn't make me feel uncomfortable, Adora; actually, you make everything feel like a dream. And that’s just the problem.”

“I- I don’t understand…”

Catra sighed tiredly. Why did she always have to struggle to talk about her feelings? Why couldn’t she just have let Adora kisses lead her into oblivion? And most importantly: why did she always have to ruin every good thing that happened in her life?

She saw Adora was confused, but so was she. Moreover, Catra couldn't understand why she felt so vulnerable and insecure, even though Adora had just expressed how much she wanted her in a clear, unprecedented way.

Talk about timing.

So Catra’s first impulse had been sprinting away from that room so she wouldn’t have to face Adora right now. That’s what the old Catra would have done; what the old Catra had actually done many times before: hurt and confuse Adora, leaving the girl alone to figure things out on her own.

But that Catra was gone. Now her pride wasn't as important as making Adora stop feeling bad when she had done nothing wrong. She had no right to hurt Adora only because she was too scared to face her own feelings.

“I'm sorry... I didn’t mean to turn you down. I really didn’t. But suddenly I heard this voice inside my head, telling me none of what’s happening is true. So I thought maybe this voice is right; maybe I’ve fallen into another portal and I’m living in this parallel universe, because… come on, Adora! You, here with me, kissing me the way you just did, wanting me the same way I want you…

this is too good to be true, right? I don’t- I don’t deserve it. I don’t deserve... *you.”*

Adora parted her lips, stunned at how easily Catra had expressed her insecurities. She could get why Catra felt that way, but Adora couldn't help shaking her head slightly at the last sentence.

Catra didn't see it, though; she had her head low as more tears flowed down her cheeks.

Clearly Catra hadn’t forgiven herself. Adora knew the past still haunted her and maybe it would haunt her for a long time. If only Catra could focus on the great things she had done recently... like saving Glimmer, befriending Melog and, on the top of it all, helping her save the world! Adora wanted to remind Catra of those things, but she knew she wouldn’t listen, at least not now. It would take time until she could come to terms with her past, but Adora would do anything within her reach to help Catra get over it.

“You are right when you say this feels like a dream, but please don’t say you don’t deserve me. You do. You’re the reason I’m here now, alive and… well, happy. The happiest I’ve ever been, as I told you before.” Adora gave her a reassuring smile and then tapped the mattress a couple of times. “Come on. It’s getting late and we are tired, so we should get some sleep. Maybe you’ll feel better in the morning, when you wake up, because the first thing you’ll see when you open your eyes is me, lying here next to you. This is not a dream, Catra. I promise. Everything is real.”

Catra nodded, still with her head low. After inhaling and then slowly letting the air out, she looked at Adora and returned her smile, quietly making her way back to bed and… lying at its foot.

Adora blinked, surprised and actually a little amused. She expected Catra to lie next to her, not on the foot of the bed like she used to do when they were cadets.

“Um, Catra?” She waited until Catra raised her head and stared directly at her. "This isn’t a single bed, you know? Since we have plenty of room now, you can lie here, next to me… Unless you prefer sleeping over there, which is totally okay too!”

"Sorry. Force of habit.”

Catra apologized while moving so she could lie face to face with Adora. Their bodies weren’t touching, but they were close enough to feel each other’s warmth.

“Thank you…” Catra murmured, “for understanding. For always understanding.”

Adora grinned and, after a moment, she asked gingerly.

“Catra… is it okay if I... hug you? Just hugging, I swear!" She quickly added. "This is not an excuse to try and jump into action, as Glimmer would say. I would never do that! I mean, I would! I definitely would! In fact, I intend to do that, but... not now. Now I just want to... you know, cuddle, if that's okay with y-”

Adora stopped mid-sentence and blinked a couple of times as Catra pressed the tip of her index finger against her forehead.

"You know, it’s kinda cute when you babble like this.” Catra chuckled and then gave Adora a quick kiss on the lips before complying to her request.

Adora’s cheeks flushed in response and she could even feel her heartbeat speeding up as Catra moved closer and rested her head on her chest.

They had never lay down so close to each other before, so only now Adora realized Catra’s body temperature was higher than hers. If only she had known that before, those nights in the Fright Zone wouldn't have been so cold. That is, supposing Catra would have agreed with it. In truth, Adora highly doubted she would; in the past, whenever someone got too close to Catra, she would quickly shove them away.

That reminded Adora of something she had always wanted to do and maybe the perfect opportunity had finally come.

“Uh, Catra… would you mind if I…” Adora let the words linger in the air, but Catra had already spotted a hand floating over her head.

“Sure. Go ahead.”

Catra shrugged and snuggled closer to Adora, brushing the tip of her nose on the crook of her neck. Adora stiffened at the light touch, trying to focus on anything but the tickling sensation caused by Catra's breathing on her neck. However, Catra mistook her lack of action for hesitation.

"That’s okay, Adora. I don’t feel uncomfortable when you touch me. Actually, I like it.”

"You do??” Adora sounded thrilled to hear that and she promptly started running her fingers through the dark hair before Catra could change her mind.

It felt smoother than Adora had anticipated. Her fingers slipped easily through the locks and soon Catra began to relax in her embrace, curling her body into a ball.

How tiny and harmless Catra could look whenever she lay down like that had always amazed Adora, but this time something else caught her attention and she giggled, staring at the girl in her arms.

“What?” Catra asked, half-asleep and half-annoyed.

"This!” Adora gestured in Catra's direction with amused fascination. "You are making a buzzing sound and your body is kinda vibrating. What is this? And how do you do that?”

“Well, this is called purr. Ask your friends, I bet they read about in those stupid books about cats.” Catra grumbled with eyes closed, before adding. "Anyway, it only happens when I’m feeling good

and relaxed. That would explain why you had never seen it before."

Adora chuckled, hugging Catra just a little tighter and resting her chin on the top of her head. She was glad she could make Catra relax to the point of *purring* and she wanted to stay up all night just watching her sleep, but Adora found herself becoming drowsy too.

At first, Adora thought she would never be able to fall asleep with Catra lying so close to her, but maybe that purr thing had some sort of relaxing effect. Although Catra's presence could really stir her up, Adora became aware that having the girl in her arms could also soothe her.

But as much as she liked cuddling, Adora couldn't help wondering what would have happened hadn’t Catra stopped them.

In a sense, she was glad they hadn’t gone all the way and that reminded her of Mermista’s comment about the last Mer-mystery book she had read. Since the story was too good, the Princess of Salineas said her first impulse had been devouring the whole book just in one go; on the other hand, she wanted to read every and each word thoroughly, to make the most of it.

That could describe perfectly how Adora felt about her relationship with Catra.

Besides, Adora knew some issues should take priority. More than feeling loved, Catra needed to overcome the idea of not being worthy, in order to trust people wouldn’t simply leave her whenever they pleased.

Perhaps the trauma caused by her parents' abandonment had triggered it all. Catra had never shown signs of interest in finding out about her family and why she had ended up in the Horde, but Adora would insistently ask Shadow Weaver those questions. So one day, after running out of patience, the sorceress blurted out

Catra had been put in a box and discarded by her parents in the Fright Zone.

For two reasons, Adora decided she wouldn't tell Catra any of that: first, she didn’t seem to care about her past and, second, knowing the truth wouldn’t do her any good.

But later on that same day, Adora caught her crying alone and, after a lot of insisting, Catra confessed she had accidentally overheard Shadow Weaver say her parents had dumped her in the Horde. Then, seeing all that hurt in her eyes, Adora promised Catra she would always look after her and that nothing really bad could happen as long as they had each other. And, from that moment on, whenever either of them needed to be reassured, the other would say exactly those same words.

However, as those memories flooded her mind in her half-sleep state, Adora had an insight. At first, Catra’s abandonment had made sense; many of the orphans raised as cadets had a similar story and Adora herself had seen it happen multiple times. But their *stepmother* had a habit of manipulating the truth, so maybe that story had been distorted too.

Adora made a mental note to ask Catra if she wanted to search for her parents, in case she had the opportunity to bring the subject up without hurting her feelings. Perhaps learning the truth about her past could help Catra heal from that trauma.

“Adora?” Catra stiffed and called her, her voice a little muffled, for her face was still buried in Adora’s neck.

Despite her own drowsiness, Adora could notice a hint of apprehension in her tone.

“Hey. I’m here.” She whispered softly, trying to soothe her.

Catra didn’t say anything, so Adora hugged her tighter, making sure she would feel her presence in case she hadn’t heard her words.

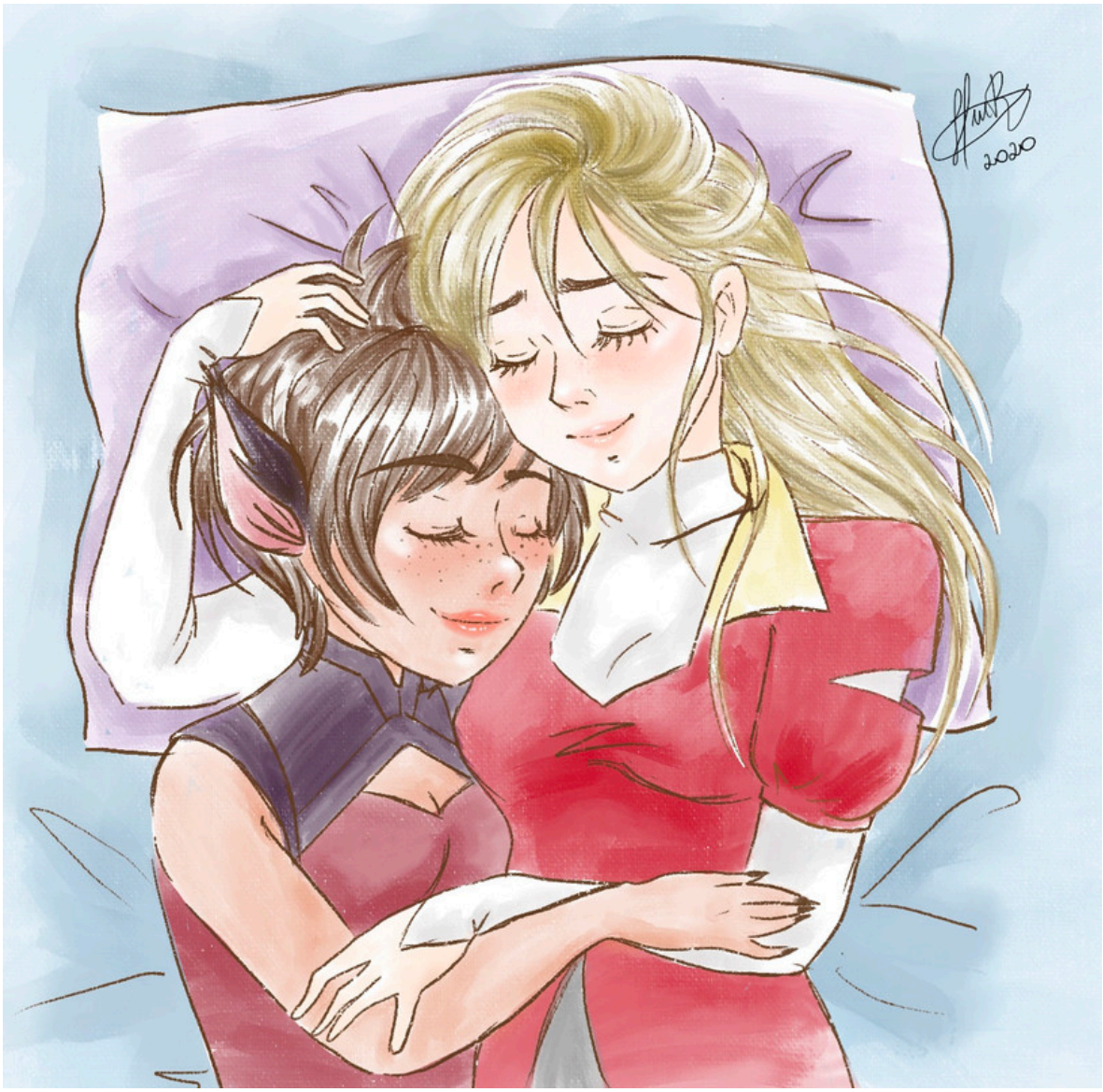
Almost immediately, Adora felt Catra's lips brush against her skin as they curled up into a smile. Under normal circumstances, that would make her shiver, but Adora was too sleepy to react.

"You'll still be here when I wake up, right?" Catra asked quietly after a moment.

"Of course I will. From now on, I will always be here when you wake up." Adora vowed, smiling with her eyes closed. "We are home. I'm not going anywhere."

"You promise?"

"I promise."



End Notes

This is dedicated to my fiancée, who strongly encouraged me to write this fic AND made this drawing for my story. Thank you, bae! ❤️

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